contrast ratio is lamented particularly in the home entertainment sphere—movies and gaming. Corporate users should not be affected by this at all.

Our game tests proved the lower contrast ratio (the specification quoting 600:1 notwithstanding). In *F.E.A.R.*, we missed enemies in dark areas due to the fact that their uniforms were also dark. Visuals are good, and the slow motion effects in the game look amazing. Were it not for the slight contrast ratio problem, the XG-C330X makes a great gaming projector as well.

Priced at Rs 1,37,000, the XG-C330X makes for a very capable all-round projector. It warrants special attention for those looking for an extremely short-throw projector. However, it is clearly geared towards the corporate segment, which is probably why performance falls short of expectations in the multimedia environment—albeit only because of a deficient contrast ratio. Overall, though, there are better options available for both business and home audiences.

BenQ MP611c

Playing with big boys is no fun...

The BenQ MP611c was the only sub XGA projector (SVGA) resolution projector we received. It's the successor to the MP610 we received last year. This is aimed by BenQ as an entry-level projector for both the business and home entertainment segments. It's surprising to see multiple D-Sub connects on the MP611c, as well as a USB port. Some of the costlier models missing out on this seems to be unforgivable, especially considering the price of this unit—a mere Rs 52,000.

Build quality is good—very good, in fact, for the price—and the body is piano-finished in dark blue. The body is a scratch magnet, as we discovered; of course, the dark colour accentuates any minor scratches picked up.

The DisplayMate suite was fired up first. We noticed some problems with bar resolution right away, owing to the drop in resolution. Our eyes had become accustomed to 1024 x 768! Despite this, it performed well in the moiré tests, but sadly, screen pixel resolution just doesn't match up.

The problem with resolution made its presence even in the colour and greyscale tests. We found serious problems with intensity transitions in each of the shades; darker colours like blue fared better. There were problems with shades even in the black and white shift tests—too many disparities noticeable.

We suggest that corporate users steer clear of the BenQ MP611c, at least in their offices. Text quality is poor with noticeable blurriness and pixilation. The same was noticeable in our photograph quality tests. The MP611c redeemed itself by a small degree in our movie tests, but the difference in quality between an SVGA projector and an XGA projector is very noticeable.

F.E.A.R. looked a little more scary than normal on this projector—due to the lack of visuals and visibility than anything else. Gaming on this projector is not a happy experience: despite the fact that there was no ghosting on-screen, deficient contrast and sharpness besmirch the gaming experience.

Choosing A Projector Screen

Buying the best projector for a given price doesn't guarantee great image quality. A little-known fact is that the quality of the projected image depends greatly on the screen used. In fact, a general thumb rule to be followed is that at least a fourth of the cost of the projector should be kept aside for the screen.

Besides the fact that screens are available in different sizes and qualities, there are also different types of screens available based on their gain values. Don't be confused by the term "gain." No screen can compensate for a low-lumen-rating projector and boost light. Gain therefore measures the brightness of the screen and its directional characteristics. However, screens today have specific characteristics themselves and are designed to perform optimally under certain specific conditions. Their characteristics are matched to factors like the size of the room, ambient light, audience viewing position, and the type of media displayed.

There are four types of screens available. Note that the first two are by far the most commonly-used screens.

High Gain

Such screens are characterised by highly reflective surfaces, and they're designed to produce bright images. Very suitable for multimedia content, or if the projector has lower brightness levels. A high gain screen is also suitable for relatively brightly-lit rooms. The only disadvantage of a high gain screen is the poor viewing angles, that is, not more than 60 degrees.

Low Gain

These screens have matte finishes and are therefore less reflective. Due to this they also enjoy the advantage of wider viewing angles—up to 100 degrees. Perceived brightness is only adequate in dim lighting, so low gain screens don't perform well in anything more than dim lighting.

Silver Lenticular

These screens were in use early in the motion picture era, but are still around. They are basically vertically ridged. They are rarely used these days for regular office or home projection purposes. Their only use remains in the projection of 3D films, because the silver dust embedded in these screens is highly reflective. Hence they are suitable for keeping two light signals segregated.

Rear Projection

As the name suggests, the projector is placed on the opposite side of the screen to the audience, that is, behind the screen. They are much more delicate and costlier than regular screens, and are therefore used in places where a fixed setup is desirous.